

The Complete

Patrick Winston Guide.

Frameworks for any presentation that needs to convince, convert, or close.

A NotebookLM Reference

Audiences are the constraint.

01

Attention is not free

Earned in the first 60 seconds. Re-earned every minute.

02

Memory is small

Audiences leave with one idea, at most. Plan which one.

03

Persuasion is structural

It is a sequence of moves. Not a charm offensive.

Upload. Pair. Audit. Iterate.

- 1 Upload this guide and your draft deck as NotebookLM sources.
- 2 Ask: 'Audit my deck against the 10 slide crimes.'
- 3 Ask: 'Apply the Star framework to my central message.'
- 4 Ask: 'Where do I violate vision-or-proof-only?'

The best presentation reference is one that audits your next talk.

Foundations.

Time, place, tools, opening crimes

Talks succeed before the speaker opens their mouth.

FACTOR	BEST	WORST
Time of day	11am	Post-lunch (1–3pm) or late evening
Day of week	Tuesday or Wednesday	Monday morning, Friday afternoon
Lighting	Bright, overhead	Dim, mood-lit
Room fullness	One-third to half full	Empty, or overcrowded
Seating	Front rows filled	Back rows filled, front empty

The same rules. Different surfaces.

FACTOR	BEST	WORST
Camera	On, well-lit, eye-level	Off • disembodied voice
Screen setup	Two screens (deck + notes)	Single screen, everything competing
Audio	External mic + headphones	Laptop mic, room speakers
Pre-share	Camera-only intro 30–60 sec	Immediate share, no presence
Tech check	30 minutes before	First click is in front of audience

The tool is a strategic choice.

Whiteboard / chalkboard

Best for: Informing

Pace of writing matches pace of audience absorption.

Slides

Best for: Persuading

Pre-prepared visuals carry rhetorical weight.

Props

Best for: Memorability

Physical objects embed in audience memory.

Whichever tool: it is secondary to YOU. Slides are condiments, not the meal.

Seven ways to lose the room in 10 seconds.

- ✗ An apology. ("Sorry I have a cold.")
- ✗ Thanks. ("Thanks for coming.")
- ✗ Your bio. ("Let me tell you about myself.")
- ✗ Context-setting. ("Let me set context first.")
- ✗ A joke. (Lands or fails. Both bad.)
- ✗ A shocking statistic. (Audiences discount these.)
- ✗ A definition. (The dictionary is not a hook.)

The Empowerment Promise.

Framework 1 of 5

Tell them what they will have.

THE RULE

The first 60 seconds are spent telling the audience what they will have, by the end of listening, that they don't have now.

THE TEST

At minute 25, will the audience be able to name what they got?

Yes → the promise worked. No → you opened with content, not empowerment.

Specific. Time-bound. Outcome-named.

"In the next [N] minutes, you will leave [knowing X / able to do Y / having decided Z]. We'll get there by [3-step preview]."

B A D

"Today I'll talk about generative AI in manufacturing. We'll cover three use cases."

G O O D

"In 25 minutes, you leave with one engagement scoped, not three options. You'll know which to fund first, the technical approach, the 90-day cost shape."

Four ways the promise breaks.

✗ Too vague

"You'll learn about AI." Not a promise; a topic statement.

✗ Too long

Beyond 90 seconds dilutes urgency. Cut.

✗ Promised, not paid

If the talk doesn't deliver, audience punishes with disengagement.

✗ Spoils the surprise

Promise the category of insight; reveal the punchline later.

THE MIRROR RULE: opening promise must be visibly kept in the close.

Slide Crimes.

Framework 2 of 5

Ten ways to put audiences to sleep.

1 Too many slides

Each slide should breathe. ~1 per 60-90 sec.

2 Too many words per slide

≤25 words content. ≤7 words headline.

3 Font under 40pt

Body text minimum. No squinting.

4 Reading slides aloud

Replaces you with text. Audience reads faster.

5 Laser pointer usage

Kills physical presence. Use click-builds.

And five more.

6

Speaker far from slides

Remote: camera off = same crime.

7

No white space or air

Empty space is breathing room. 40%+.

8

Background clutter / logos

No logo on every slide. No decorative bars.

9

Collaborators list as final slide

Ego artifact. Not content.

10

"Thank you" or "Questions?" final slide

Most common crime. Use contributions.

Flag is not enough. Specify the fix.

BAD AUDIT

"Slide 12 has too many words."

GOOD AUDIT

"Slide 12: 87 words. Cut to a 6-word headline + 3 quoted asks (4-6 words each) + outcome line (24 words). Move the rest to speaker notes."

Flag → Fix. Every crime gets a specific replacement.

Section dividers are not slide bloat.

Crime 1 says "too many slides." Section dividers appear to violate it. They don't.



Pricing.

Use case 1 of 3

Dividers create rhythmic breathing room and signal structural transitions.

Use sparingly: one per major section.

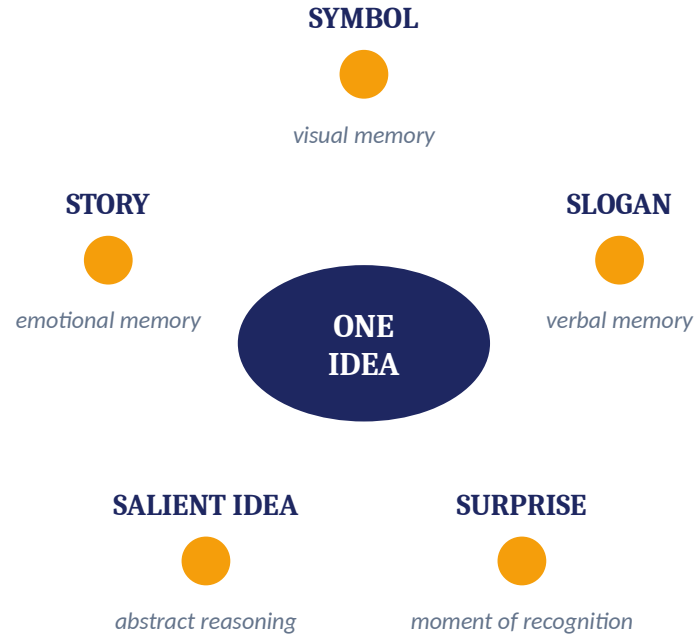
The Star.

Framework 3 of 5

Five ways to make an idea unforgettable.

ELEMENT	DEFINITION	TEST
Symbol	Visual / object representing the idea	Visual and specific. Sketchable on a napkin?
Slogan	Short phrase, the verbal handle	Repeatable in a meeting two weeks later?
Surprise	Counterintuitive truth challenging assumption	Makes audience stop and think? Not just "interesting"?
Salient idea	The ONE idea that sticks above all	Statable in one sentence with no "and" / "or"?
Story	Narrative making the idea felt, not just understood	Personal enough to be specific, universal enough to resonate?

Five elements. One idea seen from five sides.



A listener forgets four. The fifth must point back to the same idea.

Manufacturing GenAI deck.

ELEMENT	ARTIFACT
Symbol	The chassis. Two cabs (Microsoft / Google) on one chassis built once.
Slogan	"Build it once. Carry it across."
Surprise	"The fastest way to be ready for Looker is to ship on Power BI today."
Salient idea	Pay for what survives the migration.
Story	Three GenAI initiatives rebuilt because the work was tied to the BI tool.

All five point to one idea: portability prevents funding GenAI twice.

Five ways the Star collapses.

X Symbol is abstract

"Innovation" is not a symbol. A jet engine is.

X Slogan needs explanation

If you say "synergy" and explain it, it's not a slogan.

X Surprise is just interesting

"AI is changing everything" is not surprising.

X Salient idea is two ideas

"Pay for what survives AND build portably" = two.

X Story is generic

"Companies waste money on AI" is not a story.

The Job Talk.

Framework 4 of 5

Three elements. Required, not optional.

VISION

Problem they care about + new approach

Without it, audience hears tactics without strategy.

PROOF OF WORK

*Specific steps proving you've done something
real*

Without it, audience hears claims without credibility.

CONTRIBUTIONS

Final slide mirroring opening promise

Without it, the close evaporates and the decision goes with it.

Five rules. No exceptions.

- 1 Vision must be established within 5 minutes. Never later.
- 2 Proof must be specific steps. Not vague accomplishments.
- 3 Opening and close must mirror. Promise made, promise kept.
- 4 Contributions slide stays up during Q&A. Never "thank you."
- 5 Every minute advances vision or proof. Nothing else.

One sentence. Delivered verbatim. Once.

THE TEMPLATE

"[Audience] is about to [problem they care about] — unless they [new approach]. That [approach] [delivers outcome] [in time bound]."

FILLED IN

"Manufacturing CIOs are about to fund GenAI twice, once on Microsoft today, once on Google tomorrow, unless they build the layer that survives the migration first. That layer is the chassis. It ships in 90 days on the platform you already have."

Specific. Verifiable. Currently relevant.

STRONG

- ✓ "Vertex AI SDK for ABAP is GA, we've validated the call patterns."
- ✓ "Joule + Vertex AI RAG was published March 2026, here's the implementation."
- ✓ "Power BI Copilot needs Fabric F64 capacity, we've sized the cost."

WEAK

- ✗ "We have years of experience with SAP." (How many? On what?)
- ✗ "We've delivered AI for Fortune 500." (Which? What outcome?)
- ✗ "Our team is best-in-class." (Says who?)

Test: could the audience Google it and confirm in 30 seconds?

The most important slide in any pitch.

- ✓ Mirrors the opening promise. Each promise ticked off as delivered.
- ✓ Names the next action. Not "thanks." "Choose A and we start Monday."
- ✓ Stays up during Q&A. Every answer happens against this backdrop.
- ✓ Includes the salient-idea closer after the silence.

Spend disproportionate design time on this slide.

Informing.

Framework 5 of 5

Tell them three times.

The brain registers nothing on first hearing. It registers on repeat.

1

OPEN

Tell them what you'll tell them.

2

BODY

Tell them.

3

CLOSE

Tell them what you told them.

What it is. What it is NOT.

Audiences confuse new ideas with familiar ones. Distinguish explicitly.

FORMAT: "This is X. It is NOT Y."

EXAMPLE

"This is governance through structural enforcement. It is NOT governance through operational discipline. The LookML semantic layer can't be bypassed."

Tell the audience where they are.

"First..." "Second..." "Third..."

"Here's where it gets counterintuitive."

"Now I'm going to do something different."

"That was the problem. Here's the approach."

"Step back for a second."

Not filler. Navigation.

Reactivate every 10 to 20 seconds.

The brain reflexively engages with a question, even rhetorical.

- ? "Why does this matter?"
- ? "What's the obvious objection?"
- ? "What would you do?"
- ? "Sound familiar?"
- ? "Notice anything strange about that?"

All four. In two hundred words.

[VP] First, let me tell you what we found.

[CYC1] Indirect spend at this scale is being priced without historical context.

[Q] Why does this matter?

Every percent of margin recovery is \$10M annually.

[FNC] This is a retrieval problem. It is NOT a generative problem.

[CYC2] A retrieval-grounded assistant cites sources. A generative one fabricates.

[VP] So the recommendation is...

Inspiration.

The implicit fifth framework

Audiences detect speaker investment in microseconds.

1

Be passionate, visibly

Not performance, content. Talk about something you actually care about.

2

Show you've taken a risk

Skin in the game is detectable and persuasive.

3

Connect to larger meaning

Specifics anchor; meaning sustains.

4

Don't overdo it

Manufactured passion is detectable and damaging.

Synthesis.

The unified checklist

The unified Winston checklist.

OPENING

- ☐ Empowerment promise (≤ 90 sec)
- ☐ Vision sentence delivered verbatim
- ☐ No opening crime

MEMORABILITY

- ☐ Symbol identified
- ☐ Slogan repeatable
- ☐ Surprise plants real assumption
- ☐ Salient idea is ONE
- ☐ Story personal & universal

PERSUASION

- ☐ Proof of work catalogued
- ☐ Vision-or-proof every minute
- ☐ Contributions slide designed
- ☐ Salient-idea closer scripted

DISCIPLINE

- ☐ 10 crimes audited
- ☐ ≤ 25 words / ≤ 7 headline
- ☐ 40pt minimum
- ☐ No thank-you, no collaborators

The Winston quick reference card.

TIME	11am · well-lit · 1/3 to 1/2 full
OPEN	empowerment promise (≤ 90 sec)
VISION	in 5 min, one sentence, audience-is-about-to-X-unless-Y
STAR	symbol · slogan · surprise · salient idea · story
JOB	vision · proof · contributions
INFORM	cycle · fence · punctuation · question (every 10–20s)
SLIDES	≤ 25 words · ≤ 7 headline · 40pt min · 40% white
CRIMES	no thank-you · no collaborators · no laser · no apology
CLOSE	contributions stays up · salient idea after silence

Six prompts to feed NotebookLM.

"Audit my deck against the 10 slide crimes. Be strict."

"Apply the Star to my central message. Generate Symbol, Slogan, Surprise, Salient idea, Story."

"Where do I violate vision-or-proof-only?"

"Generate 5 hostile audience questions, with response frameworks."

"Compress my 25-slide deck to 12 without weakening vision or proof."

"Apply the fence rule. What's my idea NOT?"

Use this. Then ignore it.

- | | | | |
|-----------------------|---|----------------------------|--|
| ✓ Foundations | <i>time, place, tools, opening crimes</i> | ✓ Empowerment | <i>the opening that earns attention</i> |
| ✓ Slide crimes | <i>ten failures, each with a specific fix</i> | ✓ Star | <i>five elements, one idea</i> |
| ✓ Job talk | <i>vision, proof, contributions</i> | ✓ Informing | <i>cycle, fence, punctuation, question</i> |
| ✓ Inspiration | <i>four principles for sincerity</i> | ✓ Unified checklist | <i>auditable, NotebookLM-ready</i> |

Once internalized, the frameworks become second nature, and the checklist becomes unnecessary.